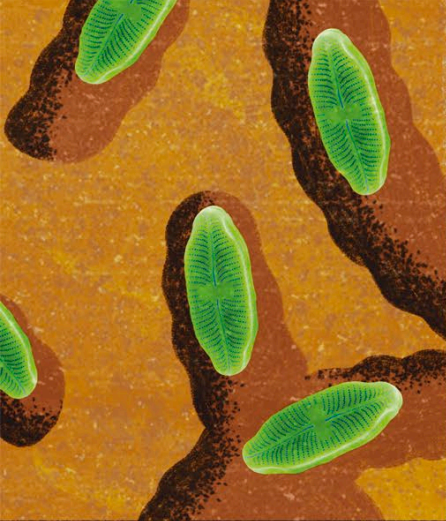




Single cells

Living things are made up of miniscule parts called cells. You contain trillions of them! However, most microbes are 'single celled' — the whole creature is made of just one cell.



Trouble makers

Some soil microbes make plants ill. Raindrops can splash off soil, picking up and carrying these microbes to the leaves of plants above. Little plants on the ground can stop this from happening by catching the raindrops before they splash on the soil.



Hidden heroes

Microbes can do good things for plants. Some protect the roots of plants by releasing chemicals called antibiotics. These kill other microbes that can harm plants and improve the plant's ability to fight off disease. On top of that, some of them glow in the dark!



Soil spaces

Microbes help to keep a good structure in soil. They create tunnels and caverns, and make a special glue that keeps the spaces open. Water and air, which plants need to stay alive, move through these spaces.



Microbes decompose (break down) leaves.

Soil

You don't need a microscope to see large clumps of white, fluffy fungi. Underground, fungi make sticky substances that help stop tiny spaces from collapsing. These spaces keep water and air in the soil.